JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 4: Health & Emergency Awareness

Module 2 - First Aid Essentials

Module Overview

First aid is the immediate, temporary care given to an injured or suddenly ill person before professional medical help arrives — and in many emergencies, it is this gap that decides whether someone recovers fully or not at all. This handbook is Module 2 of JanGyan's Health & Emergency Awareness category, teaching every citizen — students, working professionals, parents, drivers, and senior citizens — the essential first aid skills needed to respond confidently and safely.

By the end of this handbook, you will know how to handle the most common injuries and emergencies, know exactly when to call for professional help, and understand the legal protections you have as someone who steps forward to help. This module is designed as a complete, self-sufficient guide.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Explain what first aid is and its three core aims.
- Follow a safe, structured approach (DRSABC) to any emergency.
- Assemble and maintain a basic first aid kit.
- Treat common injuries — cuts, burns, nosebleeds, fractures, and sprains — correctly.
- Respond to a choking emergency in adults and infants.
- Control severe bleeding safely until help arrives.
- Recognise warning signs that need urgent medical attention.
- Understand the Good Samaritan Law and the legal protection it gives you.
- Separate common first aid myths from medically accurate facts.

Why This Topic Matters

> **Important**
> The "Golden Hour" — the first 60 minutes after a serious injury — is often the single biggest factor in survival. According to the Law Commission of India, timely and appropriate care during this window can prevent as many as half of all road accident deaths in the country.

India records road accidents at an enormous scale — the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways' *Road Accidents in India 2023* report recorded 4,80,583 accidents and 1,72,890 deaths that year, roughly 20 deaths every hour. Many of these lives are lost not at the moment of impact, but in the minutes that follow, before help arrives.

This is why first aid is not a specialised medical skill reserved for doctors and paramedics. It is a basic life skill, as fundamental as knowing how to swim safely, and every citizen benefits from learning it — especially since Indian law now protects you for stepping in to help.

Introduction

First aid is the initial, temporary help given to someone who is injured or suddenly unwell, before trained medical professionals take over. It does not replace medical treatment — its purpose is to stabilise the person, prevent the situation from getting worse, and support recovery until an ambulance, doctor, or hospital can take charge.

Definition

First Aid is the immediate assistance given to any person suffering a sudden illness or injury, using available resources, until professional medical help arrives.

Good first aid rests on three simple aims, often called the "3 P's":

Aim	What It Means
Preserve Life	Keep the person alive — clear the airway, control severe bleeding, begin CPR if trained and necessary.
Prevent Worsening	Stop the situation from deteriorating — protect from further injury, manage shock, keep the person calm.
Promote Recovery	Support healing and comfort — clean and dress wounds, reassure the person, arrange further care.

Remember

You are not expected to diagnose or cure anyone. Your role is only to stabilise and support the person until qualified help takes over.

Fundamental Concepts

1. First Aid Principles — The DRSABC Approach

Every emergency, however different, can be approached using the same simple sequence taught by organisations like the Indian Red Cross Society and St John Ambulance India:

Step	What To Do
D — Danger	Check the scene is safe for you, the person, and bystanders before approaching.
R — Response	Check if the person responds to your voice or a gentle shake of the shoulders.
S — Send for help	Call **112** (or 108/102 for an ambulance) immediately, or ask someone else to.
A — Airway	Check the airway is clear and open.
B — Breathing	Check if the person is breathing normally.
C — Circulation	Check for severe bleeding and treat it; begin CPR if trained and the person is not breathing normally.

Warning

Never move a person you suspect has a spinal or neck injury unless they are in immediate danger (fire, traffic, etc.). Moving them incorrectly can cause permanent damage — call emergency services and keep them still instead.

2. First Aid Kit Essentials

A well-stocked first aid kit, kept at home, in the car, and at the workplace, should include:

Item	Purpose
Adhesive bandages (assorted sizes)	Covering small cuts and blisters
Sterile gauze pads	Dressing larger wounds
Crepe / roller bandage	Supporting sprains and holding dressings in place
Adhesive tape	Securing dressings
Antiseptic wipes or solution	Cleaning wounds before dressing
Disposable gloves	Protecting yourself from contact with blood or fluids
Scissors and tweezers	Cutting tape or clothing, removing splinters
Digital thermometer	Checking for fever
Cold pack or clean cloth	Reducing swelling from sprains and bruises
Torch and emergency contact list	Working in low light; quick access to help

Tip

Check your kit every few months — replace anything used, expired, or damaged, especially antiseptics and adhesive items.

Complete Detailed Explanation

This section walks through each common emergency, step by step, using the same safe methods taught in standard first aid training across India.

3. Treating Cuts & Wounds

- Wash your hands or wear gloves before touching the wound.
- Apply firm, direct pressure with a clean cloth or sterile dressing to stop the bleeding.
- Once bleeding slows, rinse the wound gently with clean running water to remove dirt.
- Apply an antiseptic if available, then cover with a sterile dressing or plaster.
- Change the dressing daily, or sooner if it becomes wet or dirty.

Warning

Seek medical help if the wound is deep, won't stop bleeding after 10 minutes of firm pressure, was caused by a rusty or dirty object, or shows signs of infection (increasing redness, warmth, swelling, or pus).

4. Burns & Scalds

- Immediately cool the burn under cool (not ice-cold) running water for at least 20 minutes.
- Remove jewellery, watches, or tight clothing near the burn before swelling starts, unless it is stuck to the skin.
- Cover loosely with a clean, non-fluffy dressing or cling film.
- Do not apply ice, butter, toothpaste, or any home remedy — these can trap heat or cause infection.

- Do not burst any blisters that form.

Emergency

Seek immediate medical help for burns larger than the person's palm, burns on the face, hands, feet, or genitals, burns that look white or charred, or any burn on a child, infant, or older adult.

5. Nosebleeds

- Sit the person up and lean them slightly forward, not backward.
- Pinch the soft, lower part of the nose firmly for 10–15 minutes, breathing through the mouth.
- Avoid tilting the head back — this can cause blood to run down the throat and lead to choking or vomiting.
- Apply a cold compress to the bridge of the nose if available.

Warning

Seek medical help if bleeding continues beyond 20–30 minutes, is heavy, or follows a head injury or a blow to the face.

6. Fractures & Sprains

- Keep the injured part still and supported in the position you find it — do not try to straighten or realign it.
- If trained, support the limb with padding or a splint before moving the person.
- For a suspected sprain, use the RICE method.

RICE Step	What To Do
Rest	Stop using the injured area immediately.
Ice	Apply a wrapped cold pack for 15–20 minutes every few hours for the first 1–2 days.
Compression	Wrap firmly, not tightly, with a bandage to reduce swelling.
Elevation	Raise the injured limb above heart level where possible.

Warning

If a spinal or neck injury is suspected (for example, after a fall from height or a road accident), do not move the person at all unless there is immediate danger. Call emergency services right away.

7. Choking Response

A choking person may clutch their throat, be unable to speak, cough weakly, or struggle to breathe.

- First, encourage the person to keep coughing if they can — this is often effective on its own.
- If they cannot cough, speak, or breathe: give up to 5 sharp back blows between the shoulder blades with the heel of your hand.
- If this doesn't clear it, give up to 5 abdominal thrusts (Heimlich manoeuvre): stand behind the person, make a fist just above the navel, and pull sharply inward and upward.
- Alternate 5 back blows and 5 abdominal thrusts until the object is dislodged or professional help arrives.
- For infants under 1 year: use gentle back blows and chest thrusts instead — never use abdominal thrusts on an infant.

Emergency

If the person becomes unconscious, lower them to the ground carefully, call emergency services immediately, and begin CPR if you are trained to do so.

8. Bleeding Control

- Apply firm, direct pressure to the wound with the cleanest available cloth.
- Raise the injured area above the level of the heart, if possible, without causing more pain.
- If blood soaks through, add more layers on top rather than removing the original dressing.
- Keep steady pressure until bleeding slows or help arrives.

Warning

A tourniquet should only be used as a last resort for severe, life-threatening limb bleeding that cannot be controlled by direct pressure, and only if you know how to apply one correctly. Note the time it was applied and inform medical responders immediately.

9. When to Seek Medical Help

Warning Sign	Why It's Urgent
Severe or spurting bleeding that doesn't stop with pressure	May indicate a major blood vessel injury
Difficulty breathing or choking that doesn't clear	Life-threatening within minutes
Chest pain, pressure, or tightness	Could signal a cardiac emergency
Loss of consciousness, even briefly	Suggests a serious underlying problem
Suspected broken bone or spinal injury	Incorrect handling can cause permanent damage
Deep burns or burns on sensitive areas	High risk of infection and scarring
Head injury with confusion, vomiting, or drowsiness	Possible concussion or internal injury
Signs of severe allergic reaction (facial swelling, breathing difficulty)	Can progress to anaphylaxis rapidly

Important Terminologies

Term	Simple Meaning
First Aid	Immediate, temporary care given before professional medical help arrives.
Golden Hour	The first hour after a serious injury, when timely care most improves survival chances.
CPR	Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation — chest compressions and rescue breaths used when someone isn't breathing normally.
Vital Signs	Key indicators of life — breathing, pulse, and level of response.
Shock (medical)	A dangerous drop in blood flow to the body's organs, often following severe injury or blood loss.
Sterile	Free from germs — important for dressings placed on open wounds.

Splint	A rigid support used to keep an injured limb still.
Tourniquet	A tight band used as a last resort to stop severe, life-threatening limb bleeding.
Anaphylaxis	A severe, rapid, life-threatening allergic reaction.
Recovery Position	A side-lying position that keeps an unconscious but breathing person's airway clear.

Step-by-Step Understanding

Putting DRSABC Into Practice

1. **Assess the scene:** Look for danger before you move toward the person.
2. **Check response:** Speak loudly and gently shake the shoulders.
3. **Call for help:** Dial 112 (or 108/102) yourself, or clearly direct a specific bystander to do it.
4. **Open the airway:** Tilt the head back gently and lift the chin, if there's no suspected neck injury.
5. **Check breathing:** Look, listen, and feel for normal breathing for up to 10 seconds.
6. **Manage bleeding or begin CPR:** Act on whichever is the immediate threat to life.
7. **Keep monitoring:** Stay with the person and keep checking their condition until help arrives.

Building a Reliable First Aid Kit

1. Start with a sturdy, clearly labelled box or bag.
2. Add the essential items listed earlier in this handbook.
3. Keep one kit at home, one in the car, and check if your workplace has one.
4. Store it somewhere every family member knows and can reach quickly.
5. Review and restock it every 3–6 months.

Real-Life Indian Examples

Example 1

When a delivery rider skidded and fell on a Bengaluru road, a passer-by trained in basic first aid applied firm pressure to a bleeding leg wound and called 108 immediately, instead of moving him. Paramedics later confirmed that controlling the bleeding early likely prevented a much more serious blood loss.

Example 2

A mother in Pune calmly gave her toddler back blows after he began choking on a piece of fruit at home, having learned the technique from a community health workshop. The blockage cleared within seconds.

Example 3

A factory worker in Coimbatore suffered a minor chemical splash burn. His supervisor immediately flushed the area with running water for a full 20 minutes rather than reaching for a home remedy, significantly limiting the damage before the ambulance arrived.

Example 4

After witnessing a two-wheeler accident, a college student in Lucknow hesitated at first, unsure if helping could get her "into trouble." Recalling what she'd learned about the Good Samaritan Law, she stopped, called for an ambulance, and stayed with the injured rider until help arrived — safely, and without any legal complications.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario	What You Should Do
A child falls and scrapes their knee, bleeding lightly	Clean your hands, rinse the wound, apply antiseptic, and cover with a plaster.
Someone touches a hot pan and burns their fingers	Run cool water over the burn for 20 minutes; do not apply ice, butter, or ointment.
A colleague twists their ankle at work	Apply RICE — Rest, Ice, Compression, Elevation — and seek medical review if swelling is severe.
Someone at a family dinner suddenly can't speak or cough	Give back blows followed by abdominal thrusts; call 112 if it doesn't clear quickly.
You witness a road accident and the rider is bleeding heavily	Apply firm direct pressure, call 108/112, and remember you are legally protected under the Good Samaritan Law.

Government Rules & Guidelines

Scheme / Guideline	Purpose
Good Samaritan Guidelines	Issued by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (2015) to protect bystanders who help accident victims.
PM RAHAT Scheme	Provides cashless treatment up to ₹1.5 lakh for road accident victims during the critical Golden Hour, via the Motor Vehicle Accident Fund.
Scheme for Good Samaritan	A ₹5,000 cash reward for individuals who help transport an accident victim to a hospital within the Golden Hour.
Factories Act, 1948 (Section 45)	Requires every factory to maintain first aid boxes — at least one for every 150 workers — under a trained person's charge.
ERSS-112	India's unified Emergency Response Support System, connecting citizens to police, fire, and medical help through one number.

Laws & Policies

The Good Samaritan Law

Issued by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways in 2015, given the "force of law" by the Supreme Court of India in *Savelife Foundation v. Union of India* (30 March 2016), and later reflected in the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019. It protects anyone who, in good faith, provides emergency assistance to an accident victim.

Protection	What It Means For You
No civil or criminal liability	You cannot be sued or prosecuted for helping in good faith.
Right to anonymity	You are not obliged to disclose your name or contact details.
No obligation to pay	You cannot be made to pay for the victim's treatment.
No repeated police or court visits	If a statement is needed, it should be recorded in a single sitting.
Hospitals must treat first	Hospitals cannot delay emergency treatment to seek payment or police clearance.

The **Factories Act, 1948 (Section 45)** separately requires every factory to keep first aid boxes readily accessible during working hours, in the charge of a person holding a recognised first aid certificate, with an ambulance room mandatory where 500 or more workers are employed.

Important Statistics

Statistic	Insight
4,80,583 road accidents and 1,72,890 deaths recorded in India in 2023 (MoRTH)	Roughly 20 deaths every hour — many in the minutes after impact, not at the moment of the crash.
Up to 50% of road accident deaths may be preventable with timely Golden Hour care (Law Commission of India)	Shows the direct, measurable value of learning basic first aid.
Two-wheeler riders account for 44.8% of road accident deaths; pedestrians 20.4%	The people most likely to need roadside first aid are riders and pedestrians.
One first aid box required for every 150 workers under the Factories Act, 1948	A long-standing legal baseline for workplace emergency readiness in India.

Suggested Visual: Infographic showing the "Golden Hour" countdown alongside the DRSABC steps.

Best Practices

- Always check the scene is safe before approaching an injured person.
- Call for professional help (112/108/102) as early as possible — don't wait until you've finished treating.
- Wear gloves or use a barrier when in contact with blood or body fluids, if available.
- Keep a stocked first aid kit at home, in the car, and know your workplace's kit location.
- Stay calm and reassure the injured person — anxiety can worsen shock.
- Learn hands-on first aid and CPR through a recognised course (Indian Red Cross Society, St John Ambulance India) whenever possible.

Common Mistakes

- Applying ice, butter, or toothpaste directly to a burn.

- Tilting the head backward during a nosebleed.
- Trying to straighten or "pop back" a suspected fracture or dislocation.
- Giving food or water to an unconscious or semi-conscious person.
- Removing a large or deeply embedded object from a wound.
- Moving someone with a suspected spinal injury unnecessarily.
- Hesitating to help out of fear of legal trouble, despite Good Samaritan protections.

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Butter or toothpaste soothes a burn."	These trap heat and increase infection risk — use cool running water instead.
"Tilt your head back to stop a nosebleed."	This can cause blood to run down the throat — lean forward instead.
"You should help a choking person by giving them water."	Water can worsen choking — back blows and abdominal thrusts are correct.
"Helping an accident victim can get you into legal trouble in India."	The Good Samaritan Law specifically protects you from civil and criminal liability.
"A tourniquet should be used for any bleeding wound."	Direct pressure is correct for almost all bleeding; a tourniquet is only a last resort.

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Call 112/108 before or while giving first aid	Don't assume someone else has already called
Apply firm, direct pressure to bleeding wounds	Don't remove a soaked dressing — add more on top
Cool a burn with running water for 20 minutes	Don't use ice, butter, or home remedies on burns
Keep a suspected fracture still and supported	Don't try to realign or straighten an injured limb
Stay with the person until help arrives	Don't leave someone with a serious injury alone

Safety Tips

Know Your Protection

Under India's Good Samaritan Law, you cannot be held civilly or criminally liable, forced to pay for treatment, or repeatedly summoned to police stations or courts for helping an accident victim in good faith.

- Protect yourself first — check for danger before stepping in.
- Use gloves or a barrier cloth if handling blood or body fluids.

- Never attempt a technique you haven't been trained in, beyond the basics in this handbook.
- Keep your own and your family's emergency contacts saved and easily accessible.

Emergency

In India, dial **112** for unified emergency response (police, fire, medical), or **108 / 102** for ambulance services, depending on your state.

Practical Checklist

First Aid Readiness Checklist

☐ A stocked first aid kit at home, checked in the last 6 months

☐ A first aid kit in the car or workplace

☐ Emergency numbers (112, 108/102) saved in every family member's phone

☐ At least one adult in the household knows the DRSABC approach

☐ Know the location of the nearest hospital or trauma centre

☐ Aware of the Good Samaritan Law protections

Quick Revision Notes

Revision

- First aid's 3 aims: Preserve life, Prevent worsening, Promote recovery.
- DRSABC: Danger, Response, Send for help, Airway, Breathing, Circulation.
- Burns: cool water for 20 minutes; never ice, butter, or toothpaste.
- Nosebleeds: lean forward, pinch the soft part of the nose.
- Choking: back blows, then abdominal thrusts (never abdominal thrusts on infants).
- The Good Samaritan Law protects anyone who helps an accident victim in good faith.

Key Takeaways

Key Takeaway

1. First aid is immediate, temporary help — not a replacement for professional treatment.
2. The Golden Hour makes basic first aid knowledge genuinely life-saving.
3. A calm, structured approach (DRSABC) works for almost any emergency.
4. Indian law protects citizens who step forward to help in good faith.
5. Knowing when to call for help is as important as knowing what to do.

Glossary

First Aid — Immediate, temporary care before professional help arrives.

Golden Hour — The first hour after serious injury, when prompt care most improves survival.

DRSABC — Danger, Response, Send for help, Airway, Breathing, Circulation — a safe emergency approach.

CPR — Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation, used when a person isn't breathing normally.

RICE — Rest, Ice, Compression, Elevation — first aid for sprains.

Good Samaritan — A person who voluntarily helps another in an emergency, now legally protected in India.

Recovery Position — A side-lying position keeping an unconscious, breathing person's airway clear.

Anaphylaxis — A severe, rapid, life-threatening allergic reaction.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the main purpose of first aid?

To preserve life, prevent a condition from worsening, and promote recovery until professional help arrives.

2. What does DRSABC stand for?

Danger, Response, Send for help, Airway, Breathing, Circulation.

3. What is the "Golden Hour"?

The first hour after a serious injury, when timely care has the greatest impact on survival.

4. Am I legally protected if I help an accident victim in India?

Yes — the Good Samaritan Law protects you from civil and criminal liability when helping in good faith.

5. What should I do first when I find an injured person?

Check that the scene is safe before approaching, then check if the person responds.

6. What is the correct way to cool a burn?

Run cool (not ice-cold) water over it for at least 20 minutes.

7. Should I apply ice directly to a burn?

No — ice can damage the skin further. Use cool running water instead.

8. How do I stop a nosebleed correctly?

Lean the person forward and pinch the soft part of the nose for 10–15 minutes.

9. Should I try to realign a fractured limb?

No — keep it still and supported in the position found, and seek medical help.

10. What does RICE stand for?

Rest, Ice, Compression, Elevation — the standard first aid approach for sprains.

11. What should I do if someone is choking and can't speak?

Give up to 5 back blows, then up to 5 abdominal thrusts, alternating until it clears.

12. Can I use abdominal thrusts on an infant?

No — use gentle back blows and chest thrusts for infants under 1 year instead.

13. How do I control severe bleeding?

Apply firm direct pressure with a clean cloth and raise the area above heart level if possible.

14. When should I use a tourniquet?

Only as a last resort for life-threatening limb bleeding that direct pressure cannot control.

15. What is the emergency number in India?

112 for unified emergency response; 108 or 102 for ambulance services, depending on the state.

16. Can a Good Samaritan be forced to pay a victim's hospital bill?

No — the law specifically protects Good Samaritans from any such obligation.

17. What is the PM RAHAT Scheme?

A government scheme offering cashless treatment up to ₹1.5 lakh for road accident victims during the Golden Hour.

18. How many first aid boxes does a factory need under Indian law?

At least one first aid box for every 150 workers, under the Factories Act, 1948.

19. Should I move someone with a suspected spinal injury?

Only if they are in immediate danger — otherwise, keep them still and call emergency services.

20. Is it safe to give an unconscious person water?

No — this can cause choking. Focus on checking breathing and calling for help instead.

21. What items should a basic first aid kit contain?

Bandages, sterile gauze, antiseptic, tape, gloves, scissors, and a cold pack, among other essentials.

22. What is anaphylaxis?

A severe, rapid, life-threatening allergic reaction requiring immediate emergency care.

23. How often should a first aid kit be checked?

Every 3–6 months, replacing used, expired, or damaged items.

24. What is the recovery position used for?

To keep an unconscious but breathing person's airway clear while awaiting help.

25. Where can I get proper hands-on first aid training in India?

Through recognised courses run by the Indian Red Cross Society and St John Ambulance India.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Tables

- Flowchart: The DRSABC sequence as a step-by-step decision chart.
- Illustration: Correct hand position for abdominal thrusts (Heimlich manoeuvre).
- Illustration: Recovery position, shown in 3 simple steps.
- Poster: "What's in a First Aid Kit" labelled diagram.
- Infographic: Good Samaritan Law protections, summarised as five icons.

Official References

- Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH), Government of India — Good Samaritan Guidelines and "Road Accidents in India 2023" report.
- Supreme Court of India — Savelife Foundation & Anr. v. Union of India & Anr., Writ Petition (C) No. 235 of 2012 (2016).
- Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019, Government of India.
- The Factories Act, 1948 (Section 45), Government of India.
- National Health Authority — PM RAHAT Scheme framework.
- Indian Red Cross Society and St John Ambulance India — standard first aid training frameworks.

Official Government Website Links

Resource	Website
Ministry of Road Transport and Highways	morth.nic.in
National Health Authority	nha.gov.in

Indian Red Cross Society	indianredcross.org
St John Ambulance India	stjohnambulanceindia.com
Emergency Response Support System	112.gov.in

Conclusion

First aid is one of the simplest, most powerful skills a citizen can learn — it costs nothing to know, yet it can mean everything in the moments that matter most. From a small cut at home to a roadside accident, the calm, structured steps in this handbook can help you respond safely and effectively, and India's Good Samaritan Law ensures you can do so without fear.

As you move ahead in the JanGyan platform, use the Practice and Quiz sections to reinforce what you've learned here, and don't hesitate to use AI Assistance whenever a doubt arises. A citizen who knows first aid is never just a bystander — they are someone's best chance.

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